

The Minister's Black Veil

Nathaniel Hawthorne · 1836

First published: The Token, 1836

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Indiana 2023 edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Twice-Told_Tales_(1837)/The_Minister's_Black_Veil (revision 9901756), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Minister's Black Veil suggest about secret sin?
- What does The Minister's Black Veil suggest about isolation?
- What does The Minister's Black Veil suggest about symbol and meaning?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Indiana 2023

9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1

Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Minister's Black Veil	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*secret sin* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Minister's Black Veil

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Nathaniel Hawthorne's life or times connects to secret sin in “The Minister's Black Veil”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (secret sin, isolation, symbol and meaning).

Standards: Indiana 2023 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2

Author biography

Nathaniel Hawthorne was born in Salem, Massachusetts, on 4 July 1804; his ancestor John Hathorne was a judge in the Salem witch trials of 1692, a family history Hawthorne felt as a burden. He later changed the spelling of his surname to Hawthorne; why is uncertain, though many link it to his discomfort with his ancestors. After graduating from Bowdoin College in 1825 he spent years writing in near-seclusion in Salem, publishing Twice-Told Tales in 1837. He lived briefly at the utopian Brook Farm community, worked at the Salem Custom House, and achieved fame with The Scarlet Letter (1850) and The House of the Seven Gables (1851). He served as U.S. consul in Liverpool and died on 19 May 1864 in Plymouth, New Hampshire.

Historical and cultural context

Set in a Puritan New England village, the story reflects the Calvinist belief that every person hides secret sin. Hawthorne's footnote mentions a real clergyman, Joseph Moody of York, Maine, who wore a handkerchief over his face after accidentally killing a friend.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in The Token, a gift annual, for 1836 (issued in late 1835); collected in Twice-Told Tales (1837).

Then: Edgar Allan Poe reviewed Twice-Told Tales in 1842 and praised Hawthorne, though he guessed that the veil hid a specific crime.

Now: Widely taught as a parable of secret sin and as an example of how a symbol can carry many meanings.

Overview (spoiler-free)

The Reverend Mr. Hooper appears one Sunday wearing a black veil over his face. He never explains it, and the village's reaction changes his life.

Main themes

- secret sin: everyone hides something.
- isolation: the veil cuts him off from love.
- symbolism and interpretation: the town's reactions reveal the town.

Why it matters

The story asks why we fear what we don't understand, and what we hide from others.

Spoilers · teacher only

He refuses to remove it even for his fiancée Elizabeth, who leaves him. He becomes an effective but lonely minister, and on his deathbed declares that every face wears a black veil.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Minister's Black Veil: Why do people react strongly to something a person wears or hides?
Prompt: Before we open The Minister's Black Veil: Why do people react strongly to something a person wears or hides?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
parable; symbol; Puritanism; ambiguity; isolation.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Nathaniel Hawthorne was born in Salem, Massachusetts, on 4 July 1804; his ancestor John Hathorne was a judge in the Salem witch trials of 1692, a family history Hawthorne felt as a burden. He later changed the spelling of his surname to Hawthorne; why is uncertain, though many link it to his discomfort with his ancestors. After graduating from Bowdoin College in 1825 he spent years writing in near-seclusion in Salem, publishing Twice-Told Tales in 1837. He lived briefly at the utopian Brook Farm community, worked at the Salem Custom House, and achieved fame with The Scarlet Letter (1850) and The House of the Seven Gables (1851). He served as U.S. consul in Liverpool and died on 19 May 1864 in Plymouth, New Hampshire. The world of the book. Set in a Puritan New England village, the story reflects the Calvinist belief that every person hides secret sin. Hawthorne's footnote mentions a real clergyman, Joseph Moody of York, Maine, who wore a handkerchief over his face after accidentally killing a friend. Publication and reception. First published in The Token, a gift annual, for 1836 (issued in late 1835); collected in Twice-Told Tales (1837). Then: Edgar Allan Poe reviewed Twice-Told Tales in 1842 and praised Hawthorne, though he guessed that the veil hid a specific crime. Now: Widely taught as a parable of secret sin and as an example of how a symbol can carry many meanings.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil" slowly and put it in my own words: On his deathbed, Hooper says that when he looks around he sees a Black Veil on every face. Next, craft. I notice "lo!" an old-fashioned exclamation that sounds like a prophet's revelation. The strongest word is "visage": it is a formal word for face, which adds weight to the sermon. Then, effect. What does Hooper mean when he says he sees a black veil on every face? My answer: The veil stands for the secret sin everyone hides; Hooper's last words accuse his neighbors of the same concealment they feared in him.

> *I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil* (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil" slowly and put it in my own words: On his deathbed, Hooper says that when he looks around he sees a Black Veil on every face. Next, craft. I notice "lo!" an old-fashioned exclamation that sounds like a prophet's revelation. The strongest word is "visage": it is a formal word for face, which adds weight to the sermon. Then, effect. What does Hooper mean when he says he sees a black veil on every face? My answer: The veil stands for the secret sin everyone hides; Hooper's last words accuse his neighbors of the same concealment they feared in him.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): The Reverend Mr. Hooper appears one Sunday wearing a black veil over his face. He never explains it, and the village's reaction changes his life. Themes to track: secret sin: everyone hides something. isolation: the veil cuts him off from love. symbolism and interpretation: the town's reactions reveal the town.

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: secret sin. Prediction: Mr. Hooper's black veil will frighten his congregation in Milford more than any sermon. Question: what does the veil hide, and why do people react so strongly to it?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Minister's Black Veil: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: secret sin. Prediction: Mr. Hooper's black veil will frighten his congregation in Milford more than any sermon. Question: what does the veil hide, and why do people react so strongly to it?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Minister's Black Veil still matter? The story asks why we fear what we don't understand, and what we hide from others.
Anchor question: Why might The Minister's Black Veil still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story asks why we fear what we don't understand, and what we hide from others.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Hawthorne often set his tales in Puritan New England, among people like his own ancestors. Why might a 19th-century writer look back at the Puritans? Answer: Accept answers such as: to question Puritan ideas about sin; to explore his family's past; to show guilt and hypocrisy.
Exit ticket: Hawthorne often set his tales in Puritan New England, among people like his own ancestors. Why might a 19th-century writer look back at the Puritans?
Answer: Accept answers such as: to question Puritan ideas about sin; to explore his family's past; to show guilt and hypocrisy.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Minister's Black Veil.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Nathaniel Hawthorne" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Nathaniel-Hawthorne); The House of the Seven Gables, "Nathaniel Hawthorne" (https://7gables.org/nathaniel-hawthorne/); Hawthorne, "The Minister's Black Veil," Twice-Told Tales (1837) (https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/508)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Hooper's motive is deliberately never explained; do not present a single reading as fact.

Lesson 2: The Minister's Black Veil

Focus: a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer

Objective: Students will analyze how symbolism develops in "The Minister's Black Veil" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Indiana 2023 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.11

Content note (alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): This section mentions drinking or a drug ("…orming the ceremony, Mr. Hooper raised a glass of wine to his lips, wishing happiness to the n…"). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: This section mentions drinking or a drug.
Suggested language: "What does this detail add to the scene?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Reverend Hooper of Milford appears one Sunday wearing a black veil over his face and never removes it. The congregation is frightened; his fiancée Elizabeth begs him to lift it and leaves him when he refuses. His preaching gains power over sinners, but he lives isolated. On his deathbed he refuses to unveil, declaring that every face around him wears a black veil.

Background: Published in 1836 in The Token. Hawthorne subtitled it 'A Parable' and noted a real minister who wore a veil after an accidental killing.

Significance: A key text for teaching symbolism and ambiguity.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What things do people hide from others? Why? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to isolation because.... Content note before we start: This section mentions drinking or a drug.
Prompt: What things do people hide from others? Why?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to isolation because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: scrupled — hesitated because of a moral doubt; neatness — tidiness and order; mildness — gentleness; pronouncing — declaring; judging formally; symptom — a sign; an indication. “scrupled”: From Latin scrupulus "small sharp stone; uneasiness," the image of a pebble in one's shoe; the verb means "to hesitate on grounds of conscience." “mildness”: Origin: an English formation from mild + -ness. “symptom”: Origin: Middle English sinthoma; earlier Medieval Latin sinthoma.
Words: scrupled: hesitated because of a moral doubt · neatness: tidiness and order · mildness: gentleness · pronouncing: declaring; judging formally · symptom: a sign; an indication

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1836 in The Token. Hawthorne subtitled it 'A Parable' and noted a real minister who wore a veil after an accidental killing. A key text for teaching symbolism and ambiguity. Symbolism: The veil is never explained; it may mean sin, sorrow, the barrier between people, or the barrier between humanity and God. Characterization: Hooper is gentle but immovable; Elizabeth is the only one who speaks to him directly. Irony: The veil makes him a better preacher ("a very efficient clergyman") because sinners feel he understands them. Watch for the black veil: the hidden self.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read “Why do you tremble at me alone” slowly and put it in my own words: On his deathbed, Hooper asks why they fear only him when everyone hides something. Next, craft. I notice it is a question that turns the accusation back on the listeners. The strongest word is “tremble”: it shows their fear, which he says they should feel about themselves too. Then, effect. Why does Mr. Hooper ask why people tremble at him alone? My answer: Mr. Hooper asks why people tremble at him alone because everyone wears a hidden veil of secret sin; his black veil only makes visible what all of them hide, so he is not the only guilty one.

> *Why do you tremble at me alone (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read “Why do you tremble at me alone” slowly and put it in my own words: On his deathbed, Hooper asks why they fear only him when everyone hides something. Next, craft. I notice it is a question that turns the accusation back on the listeners. The strongest word is “tremble”: it shows their fear, which he says they should feel about themselves too. Then, effect. Why does Mr. Hooper ask why people tremble at him alone? My answer: Mr. Hooper asks why people tremble at him alone because everyone wears a hidden veil of secret sin; his black veil only makes visible what all of them hide, so he is not the only guilty one.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: "Visage" means face; he sees every face as veiled, so the veil is a symbol of everyone's secrecy. Ask: How does this line connect to isolation? Expected: The veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). (His accusation.)

> *I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil* (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: "Visage" means face; he sees every face as veiled, so the veil is a symbol of everyone's secrecy.
Ask: How does this line connect to isolation?
Expected answer: The veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). (His accusation.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for symbolism, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Minister's Black Veil develops the idea of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. When the text says “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58), it shows this directly. He asks the crowd "Why do you tremble at me alone," and says "on every visage a Black Veil," pointing out that their fear comes from their own hidden sins.
Task: Annotate the story for symbolism, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Minister's Black Veil develops the idea of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. When the text says “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58), it shows this directly. He asks the crowd "Why do you tremble at me alone," and says "on every visage a Black Veil," pointing out that their fear comes from their own hidden sins.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What things do people hide from others? Why? Ask: is Hooper heroic, proud, or both?
Anchor question: What things do people hide from others? Why?
Facilitation: Ask: is Hooper heroic, proud, or both?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. ("I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil", The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. ("I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil", The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how symbolism shapes a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Key takeaway: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Symbolism:** The veil is never explained; it may mean sin, sorrow, the barrier between people, or the barrier between humanity and God.
- **Characterization:** Hooper is gentle but immovable; Elizabeth is the only one who speaks to him directly.
- **Irony:** The veil makes him a better preacher ("a very efficient clergyman") because sinners feel he understands them.

Themes and how they develop

- **isolation:** the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

Symbols and motifs

- **the black veil:** the hidden self.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Why do you tremble at me alone" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58) His last words begin.
- "I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58) His accusation.
- "a very efficient clergyman" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45) The irony of his success.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him.
Evidence: "I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58)
Reasoning: He asks the crowd "Why do you tremble at me alone," and says "on every visage a Black Veil," pointing out that their fear comes from their own hidden sins.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
scrupled (verb)	hesitated because of a moral doubt	*A person, who watched the interview between the dead and living, scrupled not to affirm, that, at the instant when the clergyman's features were disclosed, the corpse had slightly shuddered, rustling the shroud and muslin cap, though the countenance retained the composure of death.*	"scrupled": From Latin scrupulus "small sharp stone; uneasiness," the image of a pebble in one's shoe; the verb means "to hesitate on grounds of conscience." (Online Etymology Dictionary (hand-checked note), https://www.etymonline.com/word/scruple)
neatness (noun)	tidiness and order	*Hooper, a gentlemanly person of about thirty, though still a bachelor, was dressed with due clerical neatness, as if a careful wife had starched his band, and brushed the weekly dust from his Sunday's garb.*	
mildness (noun)	gentleness	*Hooper's mildness did not forsake him.*	"mildness": Origin: an English formation from mild + -ness. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/mildness#Etymology)
pronouncing (verb)	declaring; judging formally	*Finally, the deputies returned abashed to their constituents, pronouncing the matter too weighty to be handled, except by a council of the churches, if, indeed, it might not require a general synod.*	
symptom (noun)	a sign; an indication	*For a few moments she appeared lost in thought, considering, probably, what new methods might be tried, to withdraw her lover from so dark a fantasy, which, if it had no other meaning, was perhaps a symptom of mental disease.*	"symptom": Origin: Middle English sinthoma; earlier Medieval Latin sinthoma. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/symptom#Etymology)
exerted (verb)	put to use	*Father Hooper at, first replied merely by a feeble motion of his head; then, apprehensive, perhaps, that his*	"exerted": Origin of "exert": Latin exsertus. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/exert#Etymology)

		meaning might be doubtful, he exerted himself to speak.	
eccentric (adjective)	odd; unusual in behavior	*By persons who claimed a superiority to popular prejudice, it was reckoned merely an eccentric whim, such as often mingles with the sober actions of men otherwise rational, and tinges them all with its own semblance of insanity.*	
bridegroom (noun)	a man who has recently been married	*But the bride's cold fingers quivered in the tremulous hand of the bridegroom, and her death-like paleness caused a whisper, that the maiden who had been buried a few hours before, was come from her grave to be married.*	
secrecy (noun)	the trait of keeping things secret	*There was the nurse, no hired handmaiden of death, but one whose calm affection had endured thus long, in secrecy, in solitude, amid the chill of age, and would not perish, even at the dying hour.*	"secrecy": Origin: Middle English secretee; earlier Old French secré. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/secrecy#Etymology)
accidental (adjective)	happening by chance	*Old Squire Saunders, doubtless by an accidental lapse of memory, neglected to invite Mr.*	"accidental": Origin: Anglo-Norman accidentel; earlier Late Latin accidēntālis. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/accidental#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. What things do people hide from others? Why?
2. Where does symbolism appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with secret sin?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Mr. Hooper wear? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A black veil over his face

2. Who is Elizabeth? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Hooper's fiancée
3. What happens at the young lady's funeral? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Some fancy the corpse shudders as Hooper bends over it
4. What effect does the veil have on his ministry? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: He becomes powerful with sinners but feared
5. What does Hooper say on his deathbed? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: He sees a black veil on every face
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Minister's Black Veil" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Reverend Hooper of Milford appears one Sunday wearing a black veil over his face and never removes it. The congregation is frightened; his fiancée Elizabeth begs him to lift it and leaves him when he refuses. His preaching gains power over sinners, but he lives isolated. On his deathbed he refuses to unveil, declaring that every face around him wears a black veil.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Minister's Black Veil"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Minister's Black Veil" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "A person, who watched the interview between the dead and living, scrupled not to affirm, that, at the instant when the clergyman's features were disclosed, the corpse had slightly shuddered, rustling the shroud and…" What does "scrupled" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: scrupled: hesitated because of a moral doubt.
10. Reread: "Hooper, a gentlemanly person of about thirty, though still a bachelor, was dressed with due clerical neatness, as if a careful wife had starched his band, and brushed the weekly dust from his Sunday's garb." What does "neatness" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: neatness: tidiness and order.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Minister's Black Veil" suggest about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A key text for teaching symbolism and ambiguity.
2. Find one example of symbolism in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.13] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "Why do you tremble at me alone" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His last words begin. On characterization: Hooper is gentle but immovable; Elizabeth is the only one who speaks to him directly. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. In the passage that begins “The color rose into her cheeks, as she intimated the nature of the rumors that were already abroad in the village.”, why might Hawthorne have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.13] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Minister's Black Veil”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Reverend Hooper of Milford appears one Sunday wearing a black veil over his face and never removes it. The congregation is frightened; his fiancée Elizabeth begs him to lift it and leaves him when he refuses. His preaching gains power over sinners, but he lives isolated. On his deathbed he refuses…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Minister's Black Veil” set up that the rest of The Minister's Black Veil will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.3] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His accusation. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “a very efficient clergyman” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45): The irony of his success. On characterization: Hooper is gentle but immovable; Elizabeth is the only one who speaks to him directly. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “What things do people hide from others? Why?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does tone / mood appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with secret sin? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.13] Look for: Look for word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “Why do you tremble at me alone” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His last words begin. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in 1836 in The Token. Hawthorne subtitled it 'A Parable' and noted a real minister who wore a veil after an accidental killing. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His accusation. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he

avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A key text for teaching symbolism and ambiguity." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "a very efficient clergyman" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45): The irony of his success. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "Why do you tremble at me alone" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His last words begin. On characterization: Hooper is gentle but immovable; Elizabeth is the only one who speaks to him directly. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Minister's Black Veil" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His accusation. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Minister's Black Veil": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "a very efficient clergyman" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45): The irony of his success. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to isolation: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Hawthorne need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: "Why do you tremble at me alone" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His last words begin. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the symbolism in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.13] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His accusation. On symbolism: The veil is never explained; it may mean sin, sorrow, the barrier between people, or the barrier between humanity and God. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how “The Minister's Black Veil” treats a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Minister's Black Veil see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “a very efficient clergyman” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45): The irony of his success. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve secret sin? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “Why do you tremble at me alone” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His last words begin. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58): His accusation. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Nathaniel Hawthorne about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Useful evidence: “a very efficient clergyman” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45): The irony of his success. Theme link: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Symbolism:** look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Tone / mood**: word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Complete the quotation from paragraph 12: "There was nothing terrible in what Mr. Hooper said; at least, no violence; and yet, with every tremor of his _____ voice, the hearers quaked." Word bank: acquaintances, clergyman, expressing, melancholy

   Key: melancholy

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] Who is Elizabeth?

   A. The sexton's wife

   B. His sister

   C. Hooper's fiancée

   D. A widow in the congregation

   Key: C (Hooper's fiancée)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] What happens at the young lady's funeral?

   A. The veil falls off

   B. Some fancy the corpse shudders as Hooper bends over it

   C. The church burns

   D. Hooper weeps

   Key: B (Some fancy the corpse shudders as Hooper bends over it)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "By persons who claimed a superiority to popular prejudice, it was reckoned merely an _____ whim, such as often mingles with the sober actions of men otherwise rational, and tinges them all with its own semblance of insanity." Word bank: neatness, mildness, scrupled, eccentric

   Key: eccentric

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] Complete the quotation from The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58: "Why do you _____ at me alone"

   Key: tremble

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] What does Mr. Hooper wear?

   A. A hood

   B. A black robe only

   C. A mask

   D. A black veil over his face

   Key: D (A black veil over his face)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 3? "With one accord they started, _____ more wonder than if some strange minister were coming to dust the cushions of Mr. Hooper's pulpit."

   A. perturbation

   B. clambered

   C. bachelors

   D. expressing

   Key: D (expressing)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] Complete the quotation from The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58: "I look _____ me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil"

   Key: around

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] What does Hooper say on his deathbed?

   A. He thanks Elizabeth

   B. He confesses a crime

   C. He sees a black veil on every face

   D. He asks to be unveiled

   Key: C (He sees a black veil on every face)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Complete the quotation from paragraph 1: "The sexton stood in the porch of Milford _____-house, pulling lustily at the bell-rope." Word bank: clergyman, countenance, delicate, meeting

    Key: meeting

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 23? "One imitative little imp covered his face with an old black _____, thereby so affrighting his playmates, that the panic seized himself, and he well nigh lost his wits by his own waggery."

    A. imagination

    B. acquaintances

    C. handkerchief

    D. reputation

    Key: C (handkerchief)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] What does this passage from paragraph 25 reveal about the character or situation? "But there was one person in the village, unappalled by the awe with which the black veil had impressed all beside herself." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 25) shows the situation turning on secret sin: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The words "unappalled" and "impressed" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] What does this passage from paragraph 1 reveal about the character or situation? "Children, with bright faces, tript merrily beside their parents, or mimicked a graver gait, in the conscious dignity of their sunday clothes." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 1) shows the situation turning on secret sin: the veil separates him from everyone,

even himself (he avoids mirrors). The words “conscious” and “mimicked” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12] Analyze the word choice in “a very efficient clergyman” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The irony of his success. The evidence is “a very efficient clergyman” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45). This develops isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The words “clergyman” and “efficient” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 10 shapes its tone: “A rumor of some unaccountable phenomenon had preceded Mr. Hooper into the meeting-house, and set all the congregation astir.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “unaccountable” and “congregation” (paragraph 10) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to secret sin: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 12 to the story's treatment of secret sin: “So sensible were the audience of some unwonted attribute in their minister, that they longed for a breath of wind to blow aside the veil, almost believing that a stranger's visage would be discovered, though the form, gesture, and voice…” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 12) develops secret sin: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Its words “stranger's” and “discovered” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “The next day, the whole village of Milford talked of little else than Parson Hooper's black veil.” (paragraph 23), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating secret sin as central.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 12? “Mr. Hooper had the _____ of a good preacher, but not an energetic one: he strove to win his people heavenward, by mild persuasive influences, rather than to drive them thither, by the thunders of the Word.”

    A. perturbation
    B. influence
    C. reputation
    D. delicate

    Key: C (reputation)

18. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] What can you infer from this line? “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: His accusation. The evidence is “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). This develops isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

19. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.2] What does this passage most clearly show? “a very efficient clergyman” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45) Answer in two or three sentences, quoting one word or phrase.
    Sample answer: The irony of his success. The evidence is “a very efficient clergyman” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45). This develops isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 43 shapes its tone: “But, even amid his grief, Mr. Hooper smiled to think that only a material emblem had

separated him from happiness, though the horrors which it shadowed forth, must be drawn darkly between the fondest of lovers." Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words "happiness" and "separated" (paragraph 43) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to secret sin: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 30 shapes its tone: "Know, then, this veil is a type and a symbol, and I am bound to wear it ever, both in light and darkness, in solitude and before the gaze of multitudes, and as with strangers, so with my familiar friends." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "multitudes" and "strangers" (paragraph 30) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to secret sin: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.2] Synthesis: trace how isolation develops from the opening of "The Minister's Black Veil" to its ending. Use one quotation from each part.

    Sample answer: Near the start, "Why do you tremble at me alone" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58), which shows his last words begin. Later, "a very efficient clergyman" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 45), which shows the irony of his success. The veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

23. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "For a few moments she appeared lost in thought, considering, probably, what new methods might be tried, to withdraw her lover from so dark a fantasy, which, if it had no other meaning, was perhaps a _____ of mental disease." Word bank: neatness, mildness, symptom, scrupled

    Key: symptom

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 57 to the story's treatment of secret sin: "Father Hooper's breath heaved; it rattled in his throat; but, with a mighty effort, grasping forward with his hands, he caught hold of life, and held it back till he should speak." Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 57) develops secret sin: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Its words "grasping" and "rattled" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "And yet the faint, sad smile, so often there, now seemed to glimmer from its obscurity, and linger on Father Hooper's…" (paragraph 57), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating secret sin as central.

25. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.11] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "But the bride's cold fingers quivered in the tremulous hand of the _____, and her death-like paleness caused a whisper, that the maiden who had been buried a few hours before, was come from her grave to be married." Word bank: scrupled, mildness, neatness, bridegroom

    Key: bridegroom

26. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.2] What does this passage most clearly show? "Why do you tremble at me alone" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58) Answer in two or three sentences, quoting one word or phrase.

    Sample answer: His last words begin. The evidence is "Why do you tremble at me alone" (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). This develops isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

27. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 10 shapes its tone: "He seemed not fully to partake of the prevailing wonder, till Mr. Hooper had ascended the stairs, and showed himself in the pulpit, face to face with his congregation, except for the black veil."

Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words “congregation” and “prevailing” (paragraph 10) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to secret sin: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 12 to the story's treatment of secret sin: “The sermon which he now delivered, was marked by the same characteristics of style and manner, as the general series of his pulpit oratory.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 12) develops secret sin: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Its words “characteristics” and “delivered” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “It was tinged, rather more darkly than usual, with the gentle gloom of Mr. Hooper's temperament.” (paragraph 12), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating secret sin as central.

29. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1] What effect does the veil have on his ministry?

    A. He becomes cheerful
    B. He becomes powerful with sinners but feared
    C. He leaves town
    D. He loses his job

    Key: B (He becomes powerful with sinners but feared)

30. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1] What can you infer from this line? “Why do you tremble at me alone” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
Sample answer: His last words begin. The evidence is “Why do you tremble at me alone” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). This develops isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

31. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 48 to the story's treatment of secret sin: “At length the death-stricken old man lay quietly in the torpor of mental and bodily exhaustion, with an imperceptible pulse, and breath that grew fainter and fainter, except when a long, deep, and irregular inspiration seemed to prelude…” Use one other moment from the story as well.
Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 48) develops secret sin: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Its words “imperceptible” and “inspiration” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Suffer us to be gladdened by your triumphant aspect, as you go to your reward.” (paragraph 53), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating secret sin as central.

32. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13] Which literary element does this describe in “The Minister's Black Veil”? The veil is never explained; it may mean sin, sorrow, the barrier between people, or the barrier between humanity and God.

    A. Structure
    B. Alliteration
    C. Point of view
    D. Symbolism

    Key: D (Symbolism)

33. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
Sample answer: His accusation. The evidence is “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). This develops isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

The words “visage” and “around” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. He asks the crowd "Why do you tremble at me alone," and says "on every visage a Black Veil," pointing out that their fear comes from their own hidden sins.

34. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Father Hooper at, first replied merely by a feeble motion of his head; then, apprehensive, perhaps, that his meaning might be doubtful, he _____ himself to speak.” Word bank: neatness, scrupled, exerted, mildness
Key: exerted

35. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Which literary element does this describe in “The Minister's Black Veil”? Hooper is gentle but immovable; Elizabeth is the only one who speaks to him directly.

A. Metaphor

B. Setting

C. Hyperbole

D. Characterization

Key: D (Characterization)

36. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] In the line “A person, who watched the interview between the dead and living, scrupled not to affirm, that, at the instant when the clergyman's features were disclosed, the corpse had slightly shuddered, rustling the shroud and…”, what does “scrupled” most nearly mean?

A. hesitated because of a moral doubt

B. gentleness

C. declaring; judging formally

D. tidiness and order

Key: A (hesitated because of a moral doubt)

37. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Claim: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58).
Sample answer: He asks the crowd "Why do you tremble at me alone," and says "on every visage a Black Veil," pointing out that their fear comes from their own hidden sins. The evidence is “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58) — His accusation. This develops isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors).

38. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] In the line “Hooper, a gentlemanly person of about thirty, though still a bachelor, was dressed with due clerical neatness, as if a careful wife had starched his band, and brushed the weekly dust from his Sunday's garb.”, what does “neatness” most nearly mean?

A. declaring; judging formally

B. hesitated because of a moral doubt

C. gentleness

D. tidiness and order

Key: D (tidiness and order)

39. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Minister's Black Veil”?

    A. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle

    B. The mind's final escape at the moment of death

    C. Racial pride destroying love

    D. A symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer

    Key: D (A symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer)

40. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-GR-LIT-1] In the line “Hooper's mildness did not forsake him.”, what does “mildness” most nearly mean?

    A. gentleness

    B. hesitated because of a moral doubt

    C. tidiness and order

    D. declaring; judging formally

    Key: A (gentleness)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 11, inference 2, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	7, 3, 11, 17, 4, 10, 6, 5, 12, 13, 18, 19, 20, 21, 15, 22	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	3, 23, 5, 10, 6, 8, 17, 7, 4, 12, 13, 21, 14, 20, 22, 24	recall 9, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	6, 2, 9, 1, 25, 3, 26, 13, 19, 12, 27, 15, 21, 20, 28, 16	recall 6, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	3, 6, 25, 5, 2, 29, 13, 19, 30, 21, 27, 15, 20, 22, 16, 31	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	11, 5, 25, 6, 2, 30, 21, 27, 14, 15, 32, 28, 16, 24, 33, 31	recall 5, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Freshman	34, 3, 29, 23, 6, 12, 19, 15, 27, 20, 35, 21, 33, 24, 31, 16	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	23, 36, 34, 6, 2, 26, 32, 27, 37, 15, 20, 21, 31, 28, 16, 24	recall 5, inference 1, analysis 6, synthesis 4
College Junior	38, 29, 23, 34, 6, 39, 12, 19, 27, 15, 37, 21, 16, 31, 28, 24	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	29, 23, 34, 6, 11, 19, 32, 27, 15, 21, 20, 33, 24, 28, 31, 16	recall 5, inference 1, analysis 5, synthesis 5
Graduate / PhD	40, 23, 34, 6, 9, 26, 39, 18, 19, 20, 21, 27, 16, 28, 31, 24	recall 5, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Minister's Black Veil,” how does Hawthorne show a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the symbolism you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): In The Minister's Black Veil, how does Hawthorne develop the idea of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the symbolism in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Minister's Black Veil develops the idea of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1): Analyze how the structure of The Minister's Black Veil (where it begins, turns and ends) and its symbolism shape the reader's understanding of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1): Two readers disagree about what The Minister's Black Veil suggests about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's symbolism and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Nathaniel Hawthorne uses symbolism in The Minister's Black Veil to complicate the reader's understanding of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Situate The Minister's Black Veil within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Read The Minister's Black Veil alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer follows or bends those conventions, using the symbolism as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Minister's Black Veil and its treatment of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's symbolism and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Minister's Black Veil as evidence for a larger claim about a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer in The Minister's Black Veil. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Minister's Black Veil as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer.

Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Minister's Black Veil.

SAT-style questions

1. *Hooper's mildness did not forsake him.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “mildness” most nearly mean?

   A. gentleness

   B. a man who has recently been married

   C. the trait of keeping things secret

   D. happening by chance

2. *The color rose into her cheeks, as she intimated the nature of the rumors that were already abroad in the village. But Mr. Hooper's mildness did not forsake him. He even smiled again—that same sad smile, which always appeared like a faint glimmering of light, proceeding from the obscurity beneath the veil.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Minister's Black Veil”?

   A. Harlem as promised refuge and trap

   B. A girl choosing nature over a stranger's approval

   C. Friendship tested by duty

   D. A symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer

SAT key: 1. A (gentleness); 2. D (A symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer)

Unit test

The Minister's Black Veil: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Complete the quotation from paragraph 10: “It was strange to observe, how slowly this venerable man became conscious of something singular in the _____ of his pastor.” Word bank: appearance, handkerchief, countenance, reputation

   Key: appearance

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Complete the quotation from paragraph 11: “Such was the effect of this simple piece of crape, that more than one woman of _____ nerves was forced to leave the meeting-house.” Word bank: delicate, clergyman, consciousness, countenance

   Key: delicate

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Complete the quotation from paragraph 10: “Few could refrain from twisting their heads towards the door; many stood upright, and turned directly about; while several little boys _____ upon the seats, and came down again with a terrible racket.” Word bank: clambered, consciousness, handkerchief, perturbation

   Key: clambered

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 10? “It shook with his measured breath as he gave out the psalm; it threw its obscurity between him and the holy page, as he read the Scriptures; and while he prayed, the veil lay heavily on his uplifted _____.”

   A. meeting
   B. countenance
   C. bachelors
   D. clambered

   Key: B (countenance)

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 1? “Spruce _____ looked sidelong at the pretty maidens, and fancied that the sabbath sunshine made them prettier than on week-days.”

   A. clergyman
   B. bachelors
   C. consciousness

D. handkerchief

Key: B (bachelors)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Complete the quotation from paragraph 1: “The first glimpse of the _____'s figure was the signal for the bell to cease its summons.” Word bank: countenance, acquaintances, clergyman, melancholy

   Key: clergyman

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 12? “The subject had reference to secret sin, and those sad mysteries which we hide from our nearest and dearest, and would fain conceal from our own _____, even forgetting that the Omniscient can detect them.”

   A. perturbation

   B. influence

   C. consciousness

   D. expressing

   Key: C (consciousness)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Complete the quotation from paragraph 12: “But there was something, either in the sentiment of the discourse itself, or in the _____ of the auditors, which made it greatly the most powerful effort that they had ever heard from their pastor's lips.” Word bank: countenance, appearance, consciousness, imagination

   Key: imagination

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 10? “But Mr. Hooper appeared not to notice the _____ of his people.”

   A. consciousness

   B. acquaintances

   C. reputation

   D. perturbation

   Key: D (perturbation)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 15? “The black veil, though it covers only our pastor's face, throws its _____ over his whole person, and makes him ghost-like from head to foot.”

    A. influence

    B. countenance

    C. clambered

    D. clergyman

    Key: A (influence)

11. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.9] Complete the quotation from paragraph 23: “That, and the mystery concealed behind it, supplied a topic for discussion between _____ meeting in the street, and good women gossiping at their open windows.” Word bank: appearance, acquaintances, countenance, melancholy

    Key: acquaintances

12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] What does this passage from paragraph 12 reveal about the character or situation? “It was tinged, rather more darkly than usual, with the gentle gloom of Mr. Hooper's temperament.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 12) shows the situation turning on isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The words “temperament” and “darkly” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in the story?

    A. “Children, with bright faces, tript merrily beside their parents, or mimicked a graver gait, in the conscious dignity of their sunday…”

    B. “When the throng had mostly streamed into the porch, the sexton began to toll the bell, keeping his eye on the Reverend Mr. Hooper's door.”

    C. “The sexton stood in the porch of Milford meeting-house, pulling lustily at the bell-rope.”

    D. “Spruce bachelors looked sidelong at the pretty maidens, and fancied that the sabbath sunshine made them prettier than on week-days.”

    Key: C (“The sexton stood in the porch of Milford meeting-house, pulling lustily at the bell-rope.”)

14. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] What does this passage from paragraph 10 reveal about the character or situation? “He entered with an almost noiseless step, bent his head mildly to the pews on each side, and bowed as he passed his oldest parishioner, a white-haired great-grandsire, who occupied an arm-chair in the centre of the aisle.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 10) shows the situation turning on symbol and meaning: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The words “parishioner” and “noiseless” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

15. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] What does this passage from paragraph 53 reveal about the character or situation? “Suffer us to be gladdened by your triumphant aspect, as you go to your reward.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 53) shows the situation turning on isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The words “triumphant” and “gladdened” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 11 shapes its tone: “Yet perhaps the pale-faced congregation was almost as fearful a sight to the minister, as his black veil to them.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “congregation” and “minister” (paragraph 11) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to symbol and meaning: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 1 shapes its tone: “When the throng had mostly streamed into the porch, the sexton began to toll the bell, keeping his eye on the Reverend Mr. Hooper's door.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “streamed” and “keeping” (paragraph 1) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 38 to the story's treatment of isolation: “She made no reply, but covered her eyes with her hand, and turned to leave the room.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 38) develops isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Its words “covered” and “turned” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Oh! you

know not how lonely I am, and how frightened, to be alone behind my black veil." (paragraph 39), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating isolation as central.

19. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1] What does this passage from paragraph 39 reveal about the character or situation? "Oh! you know not how lonely I am, and how frightened, to be alone behind my black veil." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 39) shows the situation turning on symbol and meaning: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The words "frightened" and "lonely" are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 23 shapes its tone: "The next day, the whole village of Milford talked of little else than Parson Hooper's black veil." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "village" and "talked" (paragraph 23) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 54 shapes its tone: "And thus speaking, the Reverend Mr. Clark bent forward to reveal the mystery of so many years." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "speaking" and "mystery" (paragraph 54) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to symbol and meaning: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 48 shapes its tone: "But in his most convulsive struggles, and in the wildest vagaries of his intellect, when no other thought retained its sober influence, he still showed an awful solicitude lest the black veil should slip aside." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "solicitude" and "convulsive" (paragraph 48) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to symbol and meaning: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 12 shapes its tone: "Each member of the congregation, the most innocent girl, and the man of hardened breast, felt as if the preacher had crept upon them, behind his awful veil, and discovered their hoarded iniquity of deed or thought." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "congregation" and "discovered" (paragraph 12) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to symbol and meaning: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 26 to the story's treatment of symbol and meaning: "First lay aside your black veil: then tell me why you put it on.'" Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 26) develops symbol and meaning: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Its words its wording carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "Know, then, this veil is a type and a symbol, and I am bound to wear it ever, both in light and darkness, in solitude…" (paragraph 30), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating symbol and meaning as central.

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 23 to the story's treatment of symbol and meaning: “It was the first item of news that the tavern-keeper told to his guests.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 23) develops symbol and meaning: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Its words “tavern” and “guests” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “But there was one person in the village, unappalled by the awe with which the black veil had impressed all beside…” (paragraph 25), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating symbol and meaning as central.

26. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 57 shapes its tone: “And yet the faint, sad smile, so often there, now seemed to glimmer from its obscurity, and linger on Father Hooper's lips.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “obscurity” and “glimmer” (paragraph 57) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 48 to the story's treatment of isolation: “For some time previous, his mind had been confused, wavering doubtfully between the past and the present, and hovering forward, as it were, at intervals, into the indistinctness of the world to come.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 48) develops isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Its words “indistinctness” and “doubtfully” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “But in his most convulsive struggles, and in the wildest vagaries of his intellect, when no other thought retained its…” (paragraph 48), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating isolation as central.

28. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 25 shapes its tone: “As his plighted wife, it should be her privilege to know what the black veil concealed.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words “concealed” and “privilege” (paragraph 25) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

29. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 10 to the story's treatment of isolation: “There was a general bustle, a rustling of the women's gowns and shuffling of the men's feet, greatly at variance with that hushed repose which should attend the entrance of the minister.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 10) develops isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Its words “shuffling” and “variance” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “He entered with an almost noiseless step, bent his head mildly to the pews on each side, and bowed as he passed his…” (paragraph 10), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating isolation as central.

30. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 3 to the story's treatment of symbol and meaning: “All within hearing immediately turned about, and beheld the semblance of Mr. Hooper, pacing slowly his meditative way towards the meeting-house.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 3) develops symbol and meaning: the veil separates him from everyone, even

himself (he avoids mirrors). Its words “immediately” and “meditative” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “A rumor of some unaccountable phenomenon had preceded Mr. Hooper into the meeting-house, and set all the congregation…” (paragraph 10), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating symbol and meaning as central.

31. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.11] In the line “Finally, the deputies returned abashed to their constituents, pronouncing the matter too weighty to be handled, except by a council of the churches, if, indeed, it might not require a general synod.”, what does “pronouncing” most nearly mean?

    A. hesitated because of a moral doubt

    B. declaring; judging formally

    C. tidiness and order

    D. gentleness

    Key: B (declaring; judging formally)

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 59 to the story's treatment of symbol and meaning: “Still veiled, they laid him in his coffin, and a veiled corpse they bore him to the grave.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 59) develops symbol and meaning: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Its words “coffin” and “corpse” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Children, with bright faces, tript merrily beside their parents, or mimicked a graver gait, in the conscious dignity of…” (paragraph 1), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating symbol and meaning as central.

33. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] Connect this passage from paragraph 10 to the story's treatment of isolation: “Did he seek to hide it from the dread Being whom he was addressing?” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 10) develops isolation: the veil separates him from everyone, even himself (he avoids mirrors). Its words “addressing” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “Yet perhaps the pale-faced congregation was almost as fearful a sight to the minister, as his black veil to them.” (paragraph 11), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating isolation as central.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	5, 7, 3, 4, 2, 11, 8, 10, 1, 6, 13, 12, 19, 15, 20, 21, 17, 18	recall 10, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	10, 4, 7, 2, 5, 8, 9, 13, 14, 15, 13, 19, 12, 22, 17, 23, 24, 25	recall 7, inference 6, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	11, 8, 5, 1, 10, 6, 14, 12, 15, 19, 13, 13, 26, 16, 21, 20, 27, 18	recall 6, inference 6, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	5, 4, 6, 8, 3, 12, 19, 14, 13, 15, 13, 16, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30, 27	recall 5, inference 6, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	31, 2, 6, 15, 14, 13, 19, 28, 17, 23, 22, 20, 21, 30, 25, 32, 29, 27	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Freshman		

	4, 11, 8, 19, 13, 14, 15, 17, 22, 20, 26, 23, 21, 30, 29, 24, 27, 25	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 6, synthesis 5
College Sophomore	3, 1, 31, 19, 13, 15, 16, 26, 20, 23, 17, 28, 29, 18, 30, 33, 32, 27	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 6, synthesis 6
College Junior	10, 8, 19, 13, 13, 17, 16, 21, 22, 23, 20, 30, 27, 25, 33, 29, 24, 32	recall 2, inference 3, analysis 6, synthesis 7
College Senior	31, 6, 13, 15, 26, 20, 17, 22, 28, 21, 24, 18, 27, 33, 30, 25, 29, 32	recall 2, inference 2, analysis 6, synthesis 8
Graduate / PhD	6, 31, 22, 17, 16, 20, 28, 23, 21, 26, 33, 27, 24, 32, 29, 18, 30, 25	recall 2, inference 0, analysis 8, synthesis 8

Final paper

The Minister's Black Veil: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops secret sin across The Minister's Black Veil. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Minister's Black Veil and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to isolation.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Minister's Black Veil. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Minister's Black Veil finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of symbol and meaning. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor	Exemplary	Proficient	Developing	Beginning
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.	Specific, arguable and precise; it organizes every section.	Clear and arguable, but broad in places.	States a topic or a summary more than an argument.	Missing, or restates the prompt.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.	Accurate, well-chosen quotations from across the work, all cited; meets the requirement.	Accurate and cited, but clustered in one part of the work.	Too few quotations, or some inaccurate or uncited.	Little or no quoted evidence.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.	Explains how specific words, structure and devices create meaning; weighs a competing reading.	Explains the evidence, with some close reading.	Mostly summary; the link to the claim is asserted, not shown.	Summary only.
Organization	15					

		Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.	Each paragraph advances the argument; transitions show logic.	Logical order with minor jumps.	Order is loose; paragraphs repeat or drift.	No discernible structure.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.	Formal, precise, present tense; MLA format; virtually error-free.	Formal with a few errors that do not obscure meaning.	Informal or error-prone in ways that distract.	Errors obscure meaning.

Exemplar paragraph: Hooper's veil reveals more about the villagers than about him. The text makes this visible when it says “I look around me, and, lo! on every visage a Black Veil” (The Minister's Black Veil, paragraph 58). He asks the crowd "Why do you tremble at me alone," and says "on every visage a Black Veil," pointing out that their fear comes from their own hidden sins. A full paper would carry this reading through the beginning, middle and end, and answer the strongest competing reading.

Essay assignments

Essay: Secret sin

Scaffolded support (600 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Minister's Black Veil teaches about secret sin. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops secret sin in The Minister's Black Veil. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops secret sin across The Minister's Black Veil. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Minister's Black Veil (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of secret sin. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of secret sin in The Minister's Black Veil. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Nathaniel Hawthorne's choices in The Minister's Black Veil (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of secret sin, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Minister's Black Veil's treatment of secret sin in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on secret sin in The Minister's Black Veil that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on secret sin in The Minister's Black Veil. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about secret sin in The Minister's Black Veil, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on secret sin in The Minister's Black Veil, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Isolation

Scaffolded support (600 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Minister's Black Veil teaches about isolation. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops isolation in The Minister's Black Veil. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops isolation across The Minister's Black Veil. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Minister's Black Veil (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of isolation. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of isolation in The Minister's Black Veil. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Nathaniel Hawthorne's choices in The Minister's Black Veil (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of isolation, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Minister's Black Veil's treatment of isolation in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on isolation in The Minister's Black Veil that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on isolation in The Minister's Black Veil. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about isolation in The Minister's Black Veil, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on isolation in The Minister's Black Veil, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Symbol and meaning

Scaffolded support (600 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Minister's Black Veil teaches about symbol and meaning. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops symbol and meaning in The Minister's Black Veil. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Nathaniel Hawthorne develops symbol and meaning across The Minister's Black Veil. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Minister's Black Veil (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of symbol and meaning. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of symbol and meaning in The Minister's Black Veil. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Nathaniel Hawthorne's choices in The Minister's Black Veil (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of symbol and meaning, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Minister's Black Veil's treatment of symbol and meaning in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

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